[SECTION / TASTE] FEATURE LOADING 41%

MAYBE YOU JUST HAVEN'T SEEN ANYTHING ELSE

WORDS
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READ
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Every December an app tells us who we are.

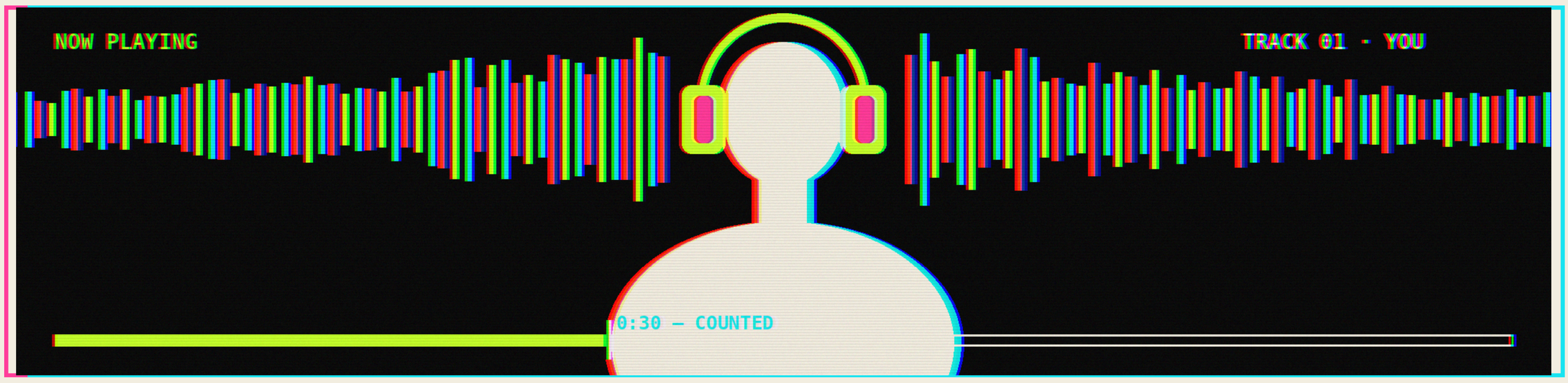


FIG. 01 — Now playing: you. Counted after thirty seconds.

"COUNTING ISN'T KNOWING."

NOTIFICATION now
Your Wrapped is ready.
See who you are.

200M
engaged with Wrapped in its first 24 hours (Dec 2025).

Every December an app tells us who we are. And people eagerly wait for its release, so they can share it and claim that's who they are. It sounds dramatic, right? But that's what happens. In 2024, Spotify Wrapped was later than usual, and "X" filled with memes and jokes about it, even though Spotify had already announced, "Almost here." When it finally arrived, people claimed it was underwhelming. Oh, we spent a whole year waiting for it to tell us about ourselves, and yes, we judged the answer.

It started small. In 2015, it was a simple roundup called "Year in Music," and it became Wrapped in 2016. By 2025, Spotify said over 200 million people had opened their year-end Wrapped within a day, and it was shared more than 500 million times.

It feels like a mirror. You listened, it counted, now it shows you yourself.

At counting, yeah, mostly. A song only counts if you play it for at least 30 seconds, so anything shorter is filtered out. The song you skipped after ten seconds never happened. Nobody saw it, nobody noticed it.

But is it right? Is it accurate? Does counting mean it knows you?

What if a song just gets counted because I played it on purpose, past thirty seconds, without even listening to it fully, enough times? Maybe Wrapped would call it mine. It wouldn't ask if I meant it. It wouldn't know.

What if I wanted people to think I liked that specific song?

Because counting isn't knowing. Songs played in a Private Session don't count toward top lists, so the one you're embarrassed about never shows up in your Wrapped. If someone else uses your account, their listening becomes yours. So maybe the artist you think is your

[SECTION / TASTE] PART 2 LOADING 83%

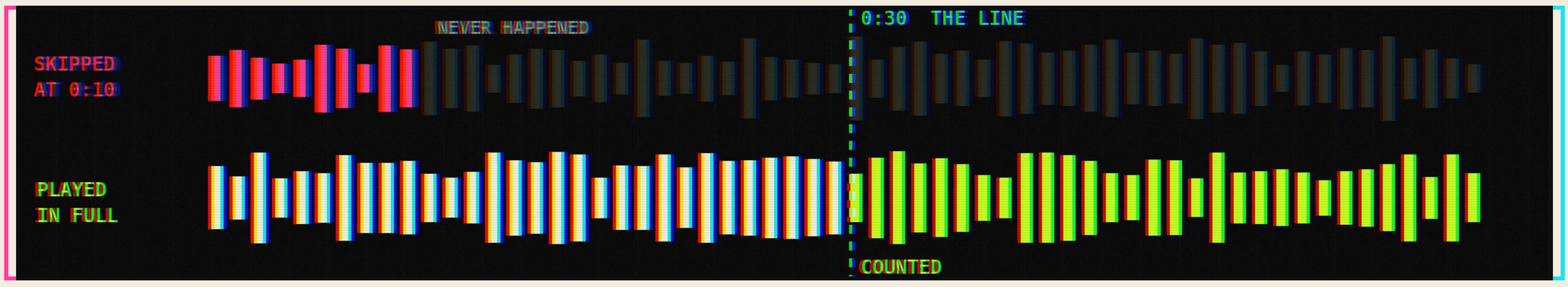


FIG. 02 — The song you skipped after ten seconds never happened.

“WRAPPED IS A RECEIPT, NOT A PORTRAIT.”

NOTIFICATION now
Top artist this year:
your dad favourite?

WRAPPED
YOUR YEAR, COUNTED.

PLAYED 30 SEC+
COUNTED

SKIPPED AT 0:10
NEVER HAPPENED

PRIVATE SESSION
NOT COUNTED

DAD USED YOUR ACCOUNT
COUNTED AS YOU

LATE NOVEMBER
NOT INCLUDED

WHY YOU PLAYED IT
NOT FOUND

TOTAL
A RECEIPT.
NOT A PORTRAIT.
THANK YOU FOR LISTENING
(WE COUNTED)

number one is actually your dad’s. You’ll never know. And it says “your year,” but it isn’t the whole year. Spotify says the data stops a few weeks before launch. So if you find a song you’re addicted to in late November, even if you play it 50 times more than the other songs, you’ll never know. The end of the year isn’t there, and it still calls it yours.

So Wrapped is a receipt, not a portrait. It knows what you played. It doesn’t know why.

And that’s the weird part. So, why did you play it?

A lot of what we listen to, nobody went looking for. Either it was just there or it found us. Netflix’s own engineers said their recommendations influence the choice for about 80% of the hours people stream. Influence, not control. Fine, but that means a lot of your “top playlist” was handed to you before you picked it.

In 2022, a famous show put a song from 1985 in a scene, and in one day its streams jumped by a thousand percent.

This year, it was a dance scene. A girl shows up at a Halloween party dressed as J.Lo. The song plays. A boy dressed in a Top Gun costume walks over and dances along. Two minutes, maybe. Then the scene from Prime was posted on every platform. A week later, a song from 2011 was on Spotify’s global chart. People went searching for it after it was handed to them, in a scene, with good lighting.

So, in December, somebody opens their Wrapped and finds one of those songs comfortably sitting in their top five. Did they pick it to sit there, or did it find its way through the show?

There is an old idea in psychology about why. In 1968, Robert Zajonc argued that seeing something again and again can make you like it more. Nobody has to convince you. It just gets familiar, and familiar starts to feel like “your taste.”

None of this makes taste fake. People have always been shaped by friends, family, ads, whatever was playing in the car. Nobody’s taste comes from nowhere. What’s different is that when a friend gave you a song, you knew a friend gave it to you. When an app does it, it just feels like you found it yourself.

So when Wrapped says who you are, what it’s really saying is who you are out of what reached you.

That makes you think about everything that didn’t. There might be a song you would have played for years. A book you’d have argued about. A movie that



FIG. 03 — A whole other version of you.

would have been your comfort movie. A whole other version of you who likes things you’ve never heard of. You don’t dislike any of it. You just haven’t seen it.

And you can’t miss something you don’t know is missing.

So, are you really what you like?

Maybe. More than the algorithm thinks, probably. It never saw your private sessions, your skips, or the things you’re okay with when no one is around.

Yes, you like the things you like. But what if you just haven’t seen anything else?